

5 SQL Questions You'll Get Asked in Every Interview

Know these cold before your next SQL round

- 1 DELETE vs TRUNCATE vs DROP
- 2 Finding duplicate rows
- 3 2nd highest salary query
- 4 Clustered vs Non-clustered index
- 5 What is a self join?

Q1

DELETE vs TRUNCATE vs DROP — what's the difference?

ANSWER

DELETE removes rows one by one (can use WHERE, logged, slower, can be rolled back).

TRUNCATE removes ALL rows instantly (minimal logging, resets identity, can't filter with WHERE).

DROP removes the entire table structure itself.

Q2

How do you find duplicate rows in a table?

ANSWER

Group by the column(s) that should be unique, then filter groups that appear more than once:

```
SELECT email, COUNT(*)  
FROM users  
GROUP BY email  
HAVING COUNT(*) > 1;
```

Q3

Write a query to find the 2nd highest salary.

ANSWER

A portable way that works even with duplicate salaries — no LIMIT/OFFSET needed:

```
SELECT MAX(salary) AS second_highest
FROM employees
WHERE salary < (SELECT MAX(salary)
                 FROM employees);
```

Q4

Clustered vs Non-clustered index — what's the difference?

ANSWER

Clustered index physically sorts and stores the table data itself in that order — only ONE per table. Non-clustered index is a separate structure that points back to the table — a table can have MANY.

Q5**What is a self join? Give an example.****ANSWER**

A self join joins a table to itself — useful for comparing rows within the same table, like finding employees and their managers in one employees table:

```
SELECT e.name AS employee, m.name AS manager
FROM employees e
JOIN employees m ON e.manager_id = m.id;
```

Which question would trip you up the most?

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Sujeet Rana

SQL Developer

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[linkedin.com/in/sujeetrana28](https://www.linkedin.com/in/sujeetrana28)